

you can still enrich the user's experience. It supports most of the DOM-based manipulation methods of JavaScript and the familiar events, functions, anonymous closures, and properties. If you're familiar JavaScript, you'll pick this up quickly (or perhaps find it maddening!). For example, if you want to provide a modal dialog box to your users:

```
<a href="#" onClick="new Dialog().showMessage('Dialog',  
'Message  
for this link');return false">Show Dialog Box</a>
```

When this code gets processed by the Facebook platform, a user will be shown the modal dialog box after clicking the Show Dialog Box hyperlink. Pretty good for a single line of code! It however differs from JavaScript in many ways. The syntax is slightly different, primarily to protect Facebook itself from malicious JavaScript code and cross-site scripting (XSS) attacks. Many DOM properties used in normal JavaScript are replaced by get/set property methods. Finally, some event handlers are not available that are widely used in normal client-side JavaScript. The use of the ubiquitous `onload()` event handler to execute code when a web page loads is not allowed. A user must take an action on the page (set focus to a control, click a mouse button, hit a key) before FBJS can execute in most locations. Facebook also wraps all FBJS in a sandbox. Basically, all FBJS variables, function names, and function parameters are prepended with a special string that ensures that no FBJS code conflicts with or can override any existing JavaScript code that might be on the page.

1.4 XFBML and the Facebook JavaScript Client Library

Applications which are based on IFrames and external sites that use Facebook Connect do not have access to FBML because of platform limitations and, therefore, don't get access to a lot of the Facebook controls and widgets it provides. To overcome these limitations, Facebook provides XFBML as well as the Facebook JavaScript Client Library which give developers access to most of the features provided by FBML. Applications that use XFBML render their pages using strict XHTML and load the Facebook JavaScript Client Library to get access to its features. These applications use the Facebook API on the client rather than the server. This means that a Facebook application can run anywhere and not just inside Facebook. Features such as logging in with Facebook credentials and publishing news stories are available in any web browser thanks to this.

After the page loads and initializes the Facebook JavaScript Client